time, our one-year training period at the Indian Military Academy (IMA), Dehradun, was compressed to seven months, and we got commissioned as second lieutenants in August 1964. It was a hectic period for hundreds of us milling around in Premnagar and Clement Town areas of IMA, Dehradun. There was a lot of ad hocism and curtailing of the training schedules being resorted to. Further, due to the increased numbers, there was an unavoidable dilution of standards of the living conditions of the cadets, particularly in the Clement Town area where I was undergoing training. We were made to live in barracks made during the Second World War to house Italian prisoners of war! My memories of that seven-month period are quite lacklustre. Except for the passing-out parade and our commissioning, I do not recall any other event. During those days, we always appeared to be in a big rush, doing one thing after another.

However, I do remember vividly the bashing up I got in the semifinals of the boxing championship. Being from the NDA, it was assumed that I was a boxer. Every cadet had to participate in the novices boxing competition in the NDA. But that did not mean we became good pugilists. Without so much as asking my concurrence, I was fielded in the bantamweight category of the IMA Inter Company Championship. I somehow managed to do well in the preliminary bouts. Being a 'southpaw' had its advantages. In the semis I had to face an adversary who happened to be a university champion and was from the emergency commission cadets' stream. In the first two rounds, I fared reasonably well. I gave him a few punches and one odd left hook, even though he had landed many solid knocks on my face, which, by then, was badly bruised. In the third round, he showed his true colours and went for me. I didn't give up. Flinging my arms about wildly and missing the target most of the time, I took a lot of beating. Barely able to stand in my corner, all that I remember was that the referee announced 'well fought red, green is the winner'. The multicoloured stars that we saw in comics as kids were all that I could see wherever I turned my eyes, and my head was pounding. Then I passed out and had to be admitted in the military hospital, where I was kept under